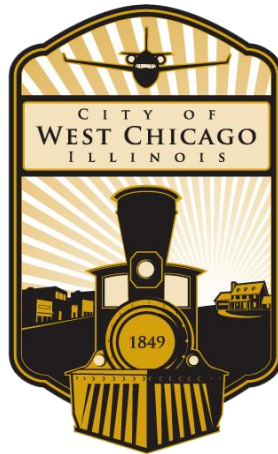


City of West Chicago

Request for Proposal (RFP) **Website Design, Development, Hosting,** **and Support Services**

May 7, 2026



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CITY OF WEST CHICAGO

REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RFP)

Website Design, Development, Hosting, and Support Services

1. PROJECT SUMMARY

The City of West Chicago (“City”) is seeking proposals from qualified firms to design, develop, host, and support a modern municipal website that will transition to a .gov domain at launch.

This project is a Citywide digital modernization initiative intended to improve service delivery, accessibility, transparency, and operational efficiency. The City is not seeking a simple website refresh, but a long-term platform that enhances how residents, businesses, and stakeholders interact with City services and information.

2. BACKGROUND

The City of West Chicago is a dynamic and diverse community located in western DuPage County, Illinois. The City provides a full range of municipal services and maintains a growing digital presence to support residents and businesses. The City’s current website serves as the primary digital gateway for information, services, payments, permits, meetings, and community updates. As content and services have expanded, opportunities have emerged to improve navigation, usability, accessibility, and content organization.

As part of this initiative, the City conducted a discovery process, including:

- A cross-departmental working group
- Internal staff surveys
- Public and stakeholder surveys

This feedback identified consistent challenges related to:

- Difficulty finding information
- Navigation and search limitations
- Outdated or inconsistent content
- Challenges completing services online
- Limited access to public documents and meeting information

3. PROJECT OBJECTIVES

This RFP intentionally focuses on outcomes and user experience, not solely technical implementation. The City is seeking a partner that can deliver a modern, effective, and sustainable digital platform that improves how the community interacts with local government. The City also intends to implement a scalable platform that supports future enhancements and evolving service delivery needs.

The City intends to implement a website that:

- Enables users to quickly find accurate information
- Provides an intuitive, accessible, and mobile-friendly experience
- Allows users to efficiently complete services and transactions online
- Improves access to public information, including meetings and documents
- Ensures content is accurate, current, and well-managed
- Reduces reliance on phone calls and in-person visits

4. PRIORITY AREAS (CORE PROJECT FOCUS)

The following priority areas are based on stakeholder input and will guide vendor evaluation and project implementation.

4.1 Find Information (Navigation & Search)

Improve the ability for users to locate information quickly through intuitive navigation and effective search functionality.

4.2 Ease of Site Use (Mobile, Usability, Accessibility, and Multilingual Access)

Ensure the website is easy to use across all devices and meets accessibility standards. The website must support multilingual access to content, including the ability to translate key pages, navigation, and service information into commonly used languages within the community.

4.3 Easily Complete Processes (Forms, Payments, Processes)

Enable users to complete services such as applications, payments, and requests efficiently online.

4.4 Clearly Identify Help (Contact & Routing)

Provide clear pathways for users to identify the correct department or contact.

4.5 Access Public Information (Meetings, Documents, Transparency)

Improve access to meeting materials, documents, and public information.

4.6 Accurate & Timely Content (Content Governance)

Ensure information is current, reliable, and clearly maintained through effective content management tools.

5. SCOPE OF WORK AND SERVICES

The selected vendor will provide a comprehensive solution addressing the priority areas identified in Section 4.

5.1 Discovery & Strategy

The vendor shall:

- Conduct user experience (UX) research and stakeholder engagement
- Validate and refine information architecture

5.2 Information Architecture & Navigation

The vendor shall:

- Develop intuitive, service-based navigation
- Implement robust, accurate search functionality
- Ensure key information is accessible within minimal clicks

5.3 Design & User Experience

The vendor shall:

- Provide a mobile-first, responsive design
- Ensure consistent usability across devices
- Meet or exceed WCAG 2.1 Level AA accessibility standards and maintain compliance with future accessibility requirements.
- Define and meet minimum website performance standards, including page load times of approximately 2 to 3 seconds under normal conditions
- Ensure the platform can handle high traffic volumes without degradation in performance
- Implement performance optimization strategies (e.g., caching, content delivery networks, image optimization)
- Maintain system stability and prevent slowdowns or interruptions during peak usage

5.4 Forms, Workflows & Online Transactions

The vendor shall:

- Provide modern digital forms (minimize PDFs where possible)
- Integrate online payment systems (currently use Illinois E-Pay and DACRA)
- Reduce incomplete or incorrect submissions
- Describe capabilities for automated workflows and routing, including how these may be implemented at launch or as a phased or optional enhancement

5.5 Contact & Service Routing

The vendor shall provide clear, service-based contact pathways that improve user navigation and reduce misdirected inquiries

5.6 Public Information & Transparency Tools

The vendor shall provide centralized, searchable access (searchability applies to both document-level and site-level access) to:

- Agendas
- Minutes
- Reports and public documents

5.7 Content Migration & Governance

The vendor shall:

- Migrate and reorganize existing content (content will be determined by each department, with the anticipation that archived content for approximately the past year will be migrated)
- Describe approach to improving accessibility and usability of document-based content, including strategies for converting or enhancing PDFs into accessible and mobile-friendly formats where appropriate
- Implement tools for:
 - content ownership
 - review and expiration
 - workflow approvals
- Reduce outdated and duplicate content
- Support management of translated content, including workflows for maintaining updates

5.8 System Integration

The vendor shall:

- Integrate with municipal systems, including:
 - Illinois E-Pay and DACRA payment platforms
 - GIS/mapping tools (ESRI ArcGIS Online is expected to continue as an external link)
 - agenda/meeting systems (not currently in use but may be considered in the future)
 - alert/notification systems (not currently in use but may be considered in the future)
- Describe available methods for integrating third-party systems, including APIs or other integration approaches
- Provide a scalable platform that supports future services and integrations

5.9 Testing & Launch

The vendor shall:

- Conduct usability, accessibility, and performance testing
- Facilitate or support an independent accessibility audit prior to launch, as directed by the City
- Support deployment and go-live

5.10 Training & Ongoing Support

The vendor shall:

- Provide staff training and documentation
- Deliver ongoing technical support and system maintenance

5.11 Analytics & Reporting

The vendor shall:

- Provide built-in website analytics or integration with standard analytics platforms (e.g., Google Analytics or equivalent)
- Enable automated reporting of key website performance metrics on a scheduled basis (e.g., monthly reports)
- Provide access to key usage data, including:
 - total visits
 - page views
 - most visited pages
 - search queries and user behavior
- Ensure analytics tools are accessible to City staff and support ongoing evaluation of website performance
- Provide dashboards or reporting tools that support data-driven decision-making

5.12 Optional Enhancements & Future Capabilities

The City recognizes that not all features or tools may be implemented at initial launch. Vendors are encouraged to identify:

- AI-powered tools such as chatbots or virtual assistants to improve user navigation and service access
- Workflow automation and routing tools to streamline internal processing and service delivery (beyond baseline capabilities)
- Optional features, modules, or tools that could enhance functionality over time
- Capabilities that may be implemented post-launch, including estimated costs and timing
- Any recommended phased approach to implementation based on priority and budget

The City may elect to include or defer these enhancements as part of the initial contract or future phases.

6. PROJECT APPROACH REQUIREMENTS

Vendors must clearly describe their approach to each of the following areas. Responses should be concise, specific, and directly aligned with the Priority Areas identified in Section 4. Vendors should also describe how website performance, usability, and success will be measured and reported over time.

6.1 Navigation & Search

Describe:

- Approach to improving findability
- Search functionality, including how users can locate information across pages, documents, and other content
- Information architecture methodology
- Tools or approaches that support conversational search or virtual assistance (e.g., chatbots), including how users may be guided to information or services through these tools

6.2 Usability, Accessibility & Multilingual Access

Describe:

- Mobile-first design approach
- Accessibility compliance strategy (WCAG 2.1 Level AA or higher)
- Accessibility testing and ongoing monitoring

Also describe:

- Translation capabilities (automated and/or managed)
- How translated content is integrated into navigation and search
- How updates to translated content are maintained
- Applicability of translation to document-based content (e.g., PDFs, reports, agendas), forms, and alerts, including any limitations
- Recommended strategies for improving multilingual access to document-based content over time

6.3 Service Completion

Describe:

- Form management capabilities
- Workflow automation and routing (including whether provided at launch or as a phased or optional enhancement)
- Payment integration
- Submission tracking and user feedback mechanisms

6.4 Contact & Routing

Describe:

- Approach to structuring service-based navigation and contact pathways

- Methods used to guide users to the appropriate department or point of contact
- Strategies to reduce misrouted inquiries and improve overall service navigation

6.5 Public Information Access

Describe:

- Approach to organizing meeting materials and public records
- Methods to improve access to and usability of public information
- How users can locate and navigate public documents and records

6.6 Content Governance

Describe:

- Content management workflows
- Methods to prevent outdated or duplicate content
- Departmental ownership and accountability tools
- Tools or approaches used to support user privacy, data protection, and compliance with applicable digital privacy standards
- Tools, scripts, or workflows available to support archiving, retention, and long-term management of website content

6.7 CMS Usability

Describe how non-technical staff will:

- Create, edit, and publish content
- Manage approvals and workflows
- Upload and organize documents
- Maintain consistency across departments
- Manage permissions and user roles

6.8 Accessibility Compliance & Maintenance

Describe:

- Accessibility testing methodology
- Tools for ongoing monitoring
- Responsibility for remediation before and after launch
- Approach to supporting or coordinating independent accessibility audits

6.9 Post-Launch Support & Infrastructure

Hosting & Infrastructure

Describe:

- Uptime guarantees (minimum 99.9%)
- Hosting environment and redundancy
- How system updates and upgrades are managed, including whether service interruptions are expected and how downtime is minimized

Cybersecurity

Describe:

- Threat protection measures
- Update and patching processes

Backup & Disaster Recovery

Describe:

- Backup frequency and retention
- Storage and security of backups
- Recovery Time Objective (RTO)
- Recovery Point Objective (RPO)
- Testing and validation procedures

Support Services

Describe:

- Support hours and response times
- Emergency support availability
- Monthly support allocation (e.g., included hours, ticket limits, or retainer-based services)
- Service level expectations for different request types (e.g., urgent, high, standard requests)
- Pricing structure for support services beyond included monthly coverage
- Methods for submitting and tracking support requests

Training & Account Management

Describe:

- Initial and ongoing training
- Account management structure

Product Updates

Describe:

- Update frequency
- Long-term roadmap
- Process for exporting all City data and content in a non-proprietary format upon contract termination

7. RFP RESPONSE REQUIREMENTS: CONTENT & FORMAT

All proposals should be clear, concise, and provide sufficient detail to minimize assumptions or the need for follow-up clarification. The City accepts no financial responsibility for any costs incurred in the preparation of proposals. Upon receipt, all proposals submitted in response to this Request for Proposals (RFP) will become the property of the City of West Chicago and are subject to applicable Illinois Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requirements.

Proposals shall include the following information and organized in the order listed below:

1. Cover Letter
2. Company Profile
3. Municipal Experience and Qualifications
 - a) Demonstrate a minimum of three (3) municipal website implementations within the past five (5) years
 - b) Describe experience working with local government organizations
 - c) Describe proven implementation methodology for municipal environments
 - d) Provide three (3) to five (5) references from comparable projects including:
 - i. project scope
 - ii. outcomes
 - iii. contact information
4. Response to Project Approach Requirements outlined in Section 6
5. Project Team and Roles
6. Project Timeline
7. Technical Solution / CMS Platform
8. Cost Proposal. Proposed fees shall be submitted as part of the proposal and should include a detailed breakdown of costs, including:
 - a) Design and development (one-time implementation)
 - b) CMS licensing (if applicable)
 - c) Hosting services
 - d) Ongoing maintenance and support
 - e) Optional features, modules, or enhancements identified in Section 5.12
 - f) Estimated costs for phased or future implementation itemsThe City reserves the right to negotiate fees with the selected vendor.
9. Availability Confirmation on June 15, 2026 for an in-person interview/demo
10. Completed Exhibit A – Functional Requirements Matrix
11. Acknowledgement of Addenda (if applicable). Vendors are required to acknowledge receipt of any formal addenda in their proposal.

Questions

Questions regarding this RFP should be submitted in writing to Kelley Chrissie, Business & Community Relations Director, at kchrissie@westchicago.org and Erik Ruiz, Communications Specialist, at eruiz@westchicago.org by **4:30pm on Wednesday, May 20, 2026**. All inquiries regarding this RFP must include the inquirer's name, firm, email and shall reference the RFP page number and

section to which it relates. A response to all written questions will be answered by an addendum that will be posted on the City's website no later than 4:30pm on Friday, May 29, 2026.

Vendors wanting to receive an email notice of any addendums should email their interest in this RFP by emailing Kelley Chrise, Business & Community Relations Director, at kchrise@westchicago.org and Erik Ruiz, Communications Specialist, at eruiz@westchicago.org by May 20, 2026.

Questions not received in a written format or received after the 4:30pm on Wednesday, May 20, 2026, are not guaranteed a response prior to the deadline for submitting the Proposal.

Proposal Submission

Vendors shall submit their proposals electronically to Kelley Chrise, Business & Community Relations Director, at kchrise@westchicago.org and Erik Ruiz, Communications Specialist, at eruiz@westchicago.org no later than **12:00pm on Monday, June 8, 2026**. The electronic submittal shall be submitted in PDF format and should have the following subject line:

Website Design, Development, Hosting, and Support Services Proposal

Selection Process

Proposals will be reviewed by a cross-departmental City staff working group. Based on initial scoring, the City anticipates selecting a shortlist of firms (approximately three) to advance to the next phase. The City reserves the right to modify the number of vendors to interview based on proposal quality.

Shortlisted vendors will be invited to participate in in-person interviews and demonstrations with the working group. These sessions will be held on Monday, June 15, and **vendors must be available for a two-hour time block on that date.**

Following interviews and demonstrations, the working group will provide a recommendation for vendor selection. The final selection will be subject to City Council approval.

Method of Evaluation

Proposals will be evaluated based on the following criteria:

- Core Website Functionality & User Experience – 45%
- Content, Transparency & Information Access – 10%
- Technical Platform & Integrations – 10%
- Municipal Experience & Implementation – 10%
- Post-Launch Support & Infrastructure – 10%
- Cost & Value – 15%

The evaluation process will include scoring by a cross-departmental staff working group, followed by in-person interviews and demonstrations for shortlisted firms.

8. PROJECT TIMELINE (ANTICIPATED)

RFP Release Date	May 7, 2026
Written Questions Due	May 20, 2026 at 4:30pm
Response to Vendor Questions	May 29, 2026 at 4:30pm
Proposal Deadline	June 8, 2026 at 12:00pm
Completion of Proposal Evaluations/Vendor Notification	June 12, 2026
Interviews/Demos by Vendors	June 15, 2026 (two-hour time slots)*
Vendor Selection	June 19, 2026
Contract Negotiation Completed	June 29, 2026
Finance Committee Meeting	July 6, 2026
Contract Approval by City Council	July 6, 2026
Project Kick-off	Mid-July
Website Launch	Q1 2027

*** Vendors must be available to meet in-person with the City on this date. The proposal should indicate availability for each 2-hour time block:**

- 8:30am-10:30am
- 11am-1pm
- 2:00pm-4:00pm

9. LIMITATION AND AWARD

This Request for Proposals (RFP) does not commit the City of West Chicago to award a contract or to pay any costs incurred in the preparation of proposals.

The City reserves the right to:

- Reject any or all proposals
- Request clarification or additional information

- Modify or cancel this RFP at any time
- Negotiate terms with the selected vendor

The selected vendor will be required to enter into a formal agreement with the City.

Exhibit A Functional Requirements Matrix

The following matrix outlines key functional requirements for the City's website. Vendors should indicate how their proposed solution meets each requirement.

Requirements are categorized to reflect implementation timing:

- **Required at Launch:** Must be included in the initial website deployment
- **Phase 1:** May be implemented shortly after launch based on priority, budget, and operational readiness
- **Future / Optional:** Enhancements that may be considered for future implementation

For each requirement, vendors shall provide:

- **Approach:** Briefly describe how the requirement is addressed within your proposed solution
- **Capability:** Indicate whether the functionality is:
 - Native (included in the core platform)
 - Configured (achieved through setup or configuration)
 - Third-party (requires integration with an external system)
 - Not currently available
- **Implementation Timing:** Confirm whether the requirement will be delivered:
 - At Launch
 - Phase 1 (post-launch)
 - Future / Optional
- **Dependencies / Assumptions** (if applicable): Identify any required integrations, data dependencies, staff responsibilities, or third-party tools
- **Additional Notes** (optional): Provide any relevant clarification, enhancements, or alternative approaches

Responses should be clear, concise, and specific. Vendors are encouraged to identify additional capabilities or alternative approaches where appropriate.

Core Website Functionality & User Experience

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Intuitive, user-centered navigation structure	High	Required at Launch
Effective, accurate site-wide search functionality	High	Required at Launch
Mobile-friendly, responsive design across devices	High	Required at Launch
Accessibility compliance (WCAG 2.1 Level AA)	High	Required at Launch

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Fast page load times and reliable performance	High	Required at Launch
Ability for users to complete forms, applications, and transactions online	High	Required at Launch
Clear service-based contact information and routing	High	Required at Launch
Ability to support multilingual translation of website pages and information	High	Required at Launch
Access to key information with minimal clicks and navigation steps	High	Required at Launch
Tools or features that assist users in locating information (e.g., guided navigation, virtual assistance)	Medium	Future / Optional
Automated workflows and routing of digital forms	Medium	Future / Optional

Content, Transparency & Information Access

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Centralized and easy access to public documents (agendas, minutes, reports)	High	Required at Launch
Searchable access to meeting materials and public records	High	Required at Launch
Content ownership and governance tools to ensure information remains current, accurate, and reliable	High	Required at Launch
Ability to organize and present boards, commissions, and public information clearly	High	Required at Launch
Strategy to improve accessibility and usability of document-based content (e.g., PDFs)	Medium	Phase 1
Website analytics and reporting capabilities to track usage and performance	Medium	Phase 1
Ability to search within documents and structured content (e.g., PDFs, City Code)	Medium	Future / Optional
Ability to provide translated access to document-based content (e.g., PDFs, reports), including options for automated or managed translation	Medium	Future / Optional

Technical Platform & Integrations

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
User-friendly content management system (CMS) for non-technical staff	High	Required at Launch
Ability to integrate with third-party systems (e.g., payment platforms, GIS, agendas, alerts)	High	Required at Launch
Scalable platform that can support future enhancements	High	Required at Launch
Flexible integration methods (e.g., APIs or equivalent approaches)	Medium	Phase 1

Municipal Experience & Implementation

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Demonstrated experience delivering municipal website projects	High	Required at Launch
Clear and structured implementation approach and timeline	High	Required at Launch
Ability to coordinate with multiple City departments during implementation	High	Required at Launch

Post-Launch Support & Infrastructure

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Reliable hosting environment with strong uptime and performance	High	Required at Launch
Backup and disaster recovery capabilities	High	Required at Launch
Defined support structure, including response times and service levels	High	Required at Launch
Ongoing staff training and support resources	Medium	Required at Launch
Tools or processes for monitoring site health (e.g., identifying content or system issues)	Medium	Phase 1
Ability to export all City data and content in a non-proprietary format	High	Required at Launch

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
Approach to minimizing downtime during system updates and upgrades	High	Required at Launch
Tools or approaches to support user privacy and data protection	Medium	Phase 1

Optional Enhancements & Future Capabilities

Requirement	Priority	Implementation Timing
AI-powered tools such as chatbots or virtual assistants	Low	Future / Optional
Advanced analytics dashboards and reporting tools	Medium	Future / Optional
Enhanced document management or automated content conversion tools	Medium	Future / Optional
Additional tools to support long-term content archiving and retention	Medium	Future / Optional